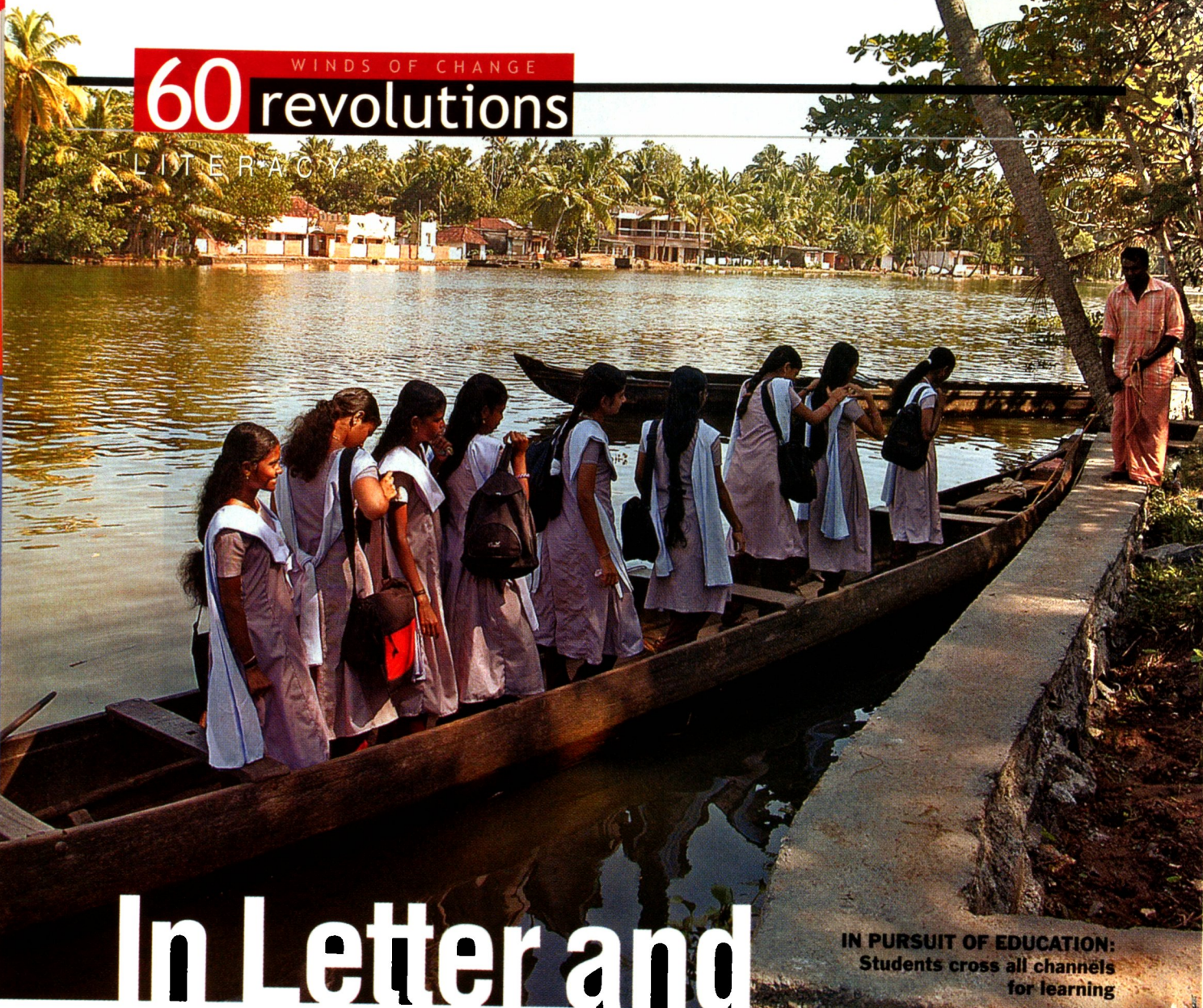




IN PURSUIT OF EDUCATION:
Students cross all channels
for learning

SHANKAR

In Letter and WITH SPIRIT

No class distinctions, age constraints or gender barriers. When it comes to education, all it takes is a passion to learn and a government with a conscience.

■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

Kottayam was well-known much before Arundhati Roy rediscovered it as the exotic backdrop for her Booker-winning *God of Small Things*. The central Kerala spice district was, from the early 19th century, a favourite haunt for English missionaries, who set up South India's first English school, Kerala's first college and the first printing press, which produced the first English-Malayalam dictionary. Kottayam had earned the honourific Land of Letters much

before it became India's first fully literate town in 1989. "So all it needed was one collective and concerted push from 85 per cent to 100 per cent literacy in 100 days," says K.J. Alphons, district collector and chief coordinator of the Kottayam People's Literacy Programme (KPLP).

Though it was just a small step forward for Kottayam, it was the first breakthrough for the Central government-backed National Literacy Mission, launched on May 5, 1988, to attain total